

« Too often, para athletes are met with sympathy instead of empathy »

# YOGESH KATHUNIYA

It's going to be special to compete at a World Championships in New Delhi. What excites me most about playing at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium is that my family will finally see me at a live international event. No one in my family has witnessed me competing at this level before. That alone gives me great motivation.

At the same time, I can't let it overwhelm me. My parents may be in the stands, but they can't throw for me. I need to stay focused on what I have to do.

**Hosting the World Championships in India is important.** It means more people will learn about para sports. With the country also bidding for the Commonwealth Games and the Olympics, organising high-profile events like this is vital. But the benefits don't stop there. When such tournaments are staged, athletes gain access to better facilities and equipment. Training schemes are launched, and younger athletes see role models up close.

That kind of exposure can inspire the next generation.

I know, because I was once that child looking for inspiration.

**My life really changed after the Tokyo Paralympics. Until then, not many people knew who I was.** In the Men's Discus Throw F56 final, I thought I had underperformed because I missed out on gold by just half a metre. Yet when I checked my phone afterwards, I had over 1,000 missed calls. I couldn't believe I had suddenly become so important. I still get goosebumps thinking about it.

At the 2024 Paralympics in Paris, I

won another silver. Again, the love and recognition I received made up for missing gold. Those moments have shown me how much sport can give, and they motivate me to aim even higher.

But my journey into sports was far from straightforward.

I grew up in Bahadurgarh, just outside Delhi. At nine, I suffered from Guillain-Barre syndrome, a neurological disease that attacked my lower limbs. At first, doctors thought I had polio. My mother even learned physiotherapy to help speed up my recovery. For a long time, I



**Everything changed in 2015 when my calipers broke. Suddenly, my limp was obvious. I felt embarrassed, but one of my seniors, Sachin Yadav, noticed. He asked me about my condition and introduced me to para sports.**